imperial army, where are the imperial elephants?'

'How could elephants with mountain-like bulk traverse four hundred karohs with the army in the space of nine days?' shouted back a scoffing Subhan Quli.

Muhammad Husain Mirza returned to his camp and readied himself for battle, doubtless with a premonition of disaster in his heart. The mirzas were defeated roundly with the Mughal army killing 2,000 of the 20,000-strong rebel army. Very few Mughal soldiers were killed but one of the few who died, Saif Khan Kokaltash, had shared an unexpected and tender destiny with Akbar. When the Padshah was a young boy, he encountered one of his milk mothers, flustered, coming back from meeting Hamida Banu Begum. On being questioned, she admitted to Akbar that having given birth to many daughters, her husband was unhappy and had warned her, 'if this time too a daughter comes I shall never cohabit with you again.' Distressed, the woman had just obtained permission from Hamida Banu to abort the child she was carrying. 'If you wish to retain our affection,' the young Akbar now told her, 'you will not touch this matter. God will bestow upon you a son of a happy star.' The woman acquiesced and the child she gave birth to was Saif Khan Kokaltash. Now Saif Khan Kokaltash had died heroically in a battle that had ended in victory for his Padshah and the legend of Akbar grew.* He literally appeared to control the destinies of his men in the palm of his hand—their divine births and their perfect deaths. His campaigns themselves were touched by an effulgence that appeared beyond the reach of ordinary mortals. Muhammad Hussain Mirza was doomed even before the battle started, when he realized that Akbar had accomplished something that had never been done before, that he had bent time and space to his will and it was partly this psychological advantage that had won Akbar the victory before the battle had even been joined. In Hindustan, kings were wont to wait for the end of the monsoon, for the cool, short winter, to declare hostilities, in preordained formations. But now the rules had scattered like dust before the monsoon storms. Now armies could cross deserts in the middle of the night and abandon war elephants if they no longer suited their purpose. Now raging rivers and unbreachable walls were there only to be conquered. As for the Padshah, he was an implacable, irresistible force who seemed to commune with the spirits and the fates. 'This Prince,' wrote Monserrate, 'is of a stature and of a type of countenance well-fitted to his royal dignity, so that one could easily